



ANCIENT INDIA

STRATEGIC REVISION BOOK

LEGENDARY IAS MENTOR



PRELIMS COMBAT 3.0

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UPSC 2025- PRELIMS COMBAT 3.0: ANCIENT INDIAN HISTORY

Table Showing Weightage and Question Trends (2015–2024)

Year	Total Questions on Ancient India	Key Topics Covered
2015	4	Indus Valley Civilization (IVC), Buddhism, Mauryan Empire.
2016	3	Gupta Empire, Vedic Period, Religious Movements.
2017	5	Vedic Age, Ashoka's Dhamma, Mahajanapadas.
2018	6	Jainism, Buddhism, Art and Culture.
2019	4	IVC Sites, Gupta Science, Sangam Literature.
2020	5	IVC Architecture, Religious Movements, Mauryan Empire.
2021	6	Religious Councils, Gupta Period, Sangam Polity.
2022	5	IVC Artifacts, Jainism, Gupta Administration.
2023	4	Ashoka's Edicts, Mauryan Administration, IVC Trade.
2024	5	Prehistoric Cultures, Early Gupta Art and Literature.

Observations

- **Consistency:** Ancient India questions range from 3-6 annually.
- **Key Areas:** Major focus on IVC, Buddhism, Jainism, Gupta Empire, and Mauryan Empire.
- **Shift in Focus:** Increasing weightage on Prehistoric Cultures and Art in recent years.

Prehistoric Cultures: Palaeolithic, Mesolithic, Neolithic

Features of Different Eras:

Period	Timeline	Tools and Technology	Lifestyle
Palaeolithic	2 million BCE	Core and flake tools, hand-axes	Hunter-gatherers, nomadic.
Mesolithic	10,000 BCE	Microliths, bow and arrow	Semi-nomadic, fishing.
Neolithic	7,000 BCE	Polished stone tools, pottery	Agriculture, permanent settlements .
Chalcolithic	3,000 BCE	Copper tools , wheel-made pottery	Early trade and barter.

Key Sites and Features:

Site	Period	Key Discoveries
Bhimbetka	Paleolithic	Rock shelters, cave paintings.
Hunsgi	Paleolithic	Stone tools and implements.
Adamgarh	Mesolithic	Cave paintings and microlithic tools.
Bagor	Mesolithic	Domesticated animals, microlithic tools.
Mehrgarh	Neolithic	Early agriculture, storage granaries.

Site	Period	Key Discoveries
Burzahom	Neolithic	Pit dwellings, polished stone tools.
Chirand	Neolithic	Neolithic tools, rice husk impressions.
Ahar	Chalcolithic	Distinctive black-and-red ware pottery.
Gilund	Chalcolithic	Early copper metallurgy .
Daimabad	Chalcolithic	Bronze chariots and artifacts.
Hallur	Neolithic	Evidence of millet cultivation.
Brahmagiri	Neolithic	Burial practices with grave goods.
Jorwe	Chalcolithic	Painted pottery and beads.
Kayatha	Chalcolithic	Ochre-colored pottery and copper tools.
Navdatoli	Chalcolithic	Settlements with painted pottery.

Map work on Prehistoric Sites:

- Paleolithic sites: Bhimbetka, Hunsgi.
- Mesolithic sites: Bagor, Adamgarh.
- Neolithic sites: Mehrgarh, Burzahom, Chirand.
- Chalcolithic sites: Daimabad, Ahar, Jorwe.

IVC: Urban Planning: Drainage, Granaries, Dockyards (IVC)

Feature	Key Sites	Description
Drainage	Mohenjo-Daro	Sophisticated drainage systems , underground pipes.
Granaries	Harappa	Massive brick structures for storage.
Dockyards	Lothal	Evidence of maritime trade , brick dockyard.
Public Baths	Mohenjo-Daro	Great Bath for ritualistic purposes.
City Planning	Dholavira	Grid pattern layout with citadel and lower town .
Water Reservoirs	Dholavira	Advanced water conservation systems .
Fortified Settlements	Kalibangan	Fortified citadel with mud-brick walls.
Fire Altars	Kalibangan	Evidence of fire rituals .
Assembly Halls	Mohenjo-Daro	Large halls for administrative or community use.
Bead Making Units	Lothal	Evidence of craft specialization.
Potter's Kilns	Harappa	Evidence of mass production of pottery.
Streets	Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro	Wide and straight streets in grid layout.

Feature	Key Sites	Description
Wells	Harappa	Private and public wells for water supply.
Warehouses	Harappa	Massive storage facilities for trade goods.
Sanitation Systems	Mohenjo-Daro	Covered drains and soak pits.
Residential Blocks	Dholavira	Standardized housing with courtyard.
Citadel	Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro	Elevated structures for elite or administrative use.
Seals Workshops	Harappa	Workshops for creating seals and artifacts.
Brick Technology	All major sites	Standardized burnt bricks for construction.

Artifacts

Seals and Scripts:

- Materials: Steatite seals with **pictographic script**.
- Notable Example: **Pashupati** seal depicting proto-Shiva.

Sculptures and Pottery:

Type	Key Features	Examples
Sculptures	Bronze, terracotta figures	Dancing Girl, Bearded Priest.
Pottery	Wheel-made, painted pottery	Red and black ware.
Beads	Semi-precious stones	Found at Lothal, Dholavira.
Tools	Copper and stone tools	Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro.
Toys	Terracotta figurines	Animal and cart models.
Ornaments	Gold, silver, shell jewelry	Found across major sites.
Inscriptions	Pictographic script on seals	Undeciphered writing system.
Weights	Standardized cubical weights	Used for trade.
Weapons	Copper and bronze tools	Axes, spears.
Utensils	Stone and metal vessels	Found in Harappan kitchens.
Religious Symbols	Swastika motifs, lingams	Ritualistic use.
Fishing Tools	Harpoons, fishhooks	Evidence of fishing.
Storage Jars	Large ceramic jars	Used for grains and liquids.
Animal Figurines	Terracotta animals	Depictions of bulls, rhinos.
Textile Evidence	Spindle whorls	Suggests cotton production.
Musical Instruments	Primitive drums, rattles	Cultural artifacts.

Mahajanapadas and Religious Movements

Mahajanapadas:

Key Features:

- **Total: 16** Mahajanapadas.
- **Dominant Kingdoms:** Magadha, Kosala, Kashi.

Mahajanapada	Capital	Distinctive Feature
Anga	Champa	Center for maritime trade.
Magadha	Rajagriha	Emergence of Mauryan Empire .
Kasi	Varanasi	Major center of trade and commerce.
Kosala	Ayodhya	Prominent under King Prasenjit.
Vrijji	Vaishali	Confederation of clans.
Malla	Kushinagar	Associated with Buddha's Mahaparinirvana .
Chedi	Shuktimati	Mentioned in Mahabharata.
Vatsa	Kaushambi	Known for economic prosperity.
Kuru	Indraprastha	Mentioned in Vedic literature.
Panchala	Ahichhatra	Associated with ancient universities.
Matsya	Viratnagar	Key mention in Mahabharata.
Surasena	Mathura	Associated with Krishna.
Assaka	Pratishthana	South Indian connections.
Avanti	Ujjain	Major trade and political center.
Gandhara	Taxila	Renowned for ancient education.
Kamboja	Rajapura	Known for horse trade .

Religious Movements:

Teachings of Jainism and Buddhism:

Aspect	Jainism	Buddhism
Founder	Mahavira	Gautama Buddha
Core Values	Ahimsa, Aparigraha, Satya	Middle Path, Four Noble Truths
Sacred Texts	Agamas	Tripitaka
Philosophy	Eternal truth, Karma, Moksha	Dependent Origination, Nirvana
Religious Councils	Pataliputra (post-Mahavira period)	Rajagriha, Vaishali, Pataliputra, Kashmir
Monastic Orders	Strict ascetic practices	Sangha with Vinaya rules
Spread	South and Western India	Across Asia via Silk Road
Symbols	Swastika, Tirthankara statues	Stupas, Bodhi Tree, Dharmachakra
Women's Role	Limited participation	Allowed in Sangha by Buddha
Key Patrons	Chandragupta Maurya, Kharavela	Ashoka, Kanishka
Ritual Practices	Extreme austerity, fasting	Meditation, non-ritualistic
Festivals	Mahavir Jayanti, Paryushan	Vesak, Asalha Puja
Art and Architecture	Jain Temples, Gomateshwara statue	Sanchi Stupa, Ajanta Caves
Ethical Codes	Five Great Vows (Mahavratas)	Eightfold Path

Jainism and Buddhism

Councils:

Council	Buddhism Location	Key Details
First Council	Rajagriha	Compilation of Sutta and Vinaya Pitakas.
Second Council	Vaishali	Schism over monastic practices.
Third Council	Pataliputra	Sponsored by Ashoka to propagate Dhamma.
Fourth Council	Kashmir (Kanishka's reign)	Compilation of Mahayana texts.

Council	Jainism Location	Key Details
First Council	Pataliputra	Compilation of 12 Angas.
Second Council	Valabhi	Final codification of Jain texts.

Spread of Buddhism and Jainism

Buddhism:

- **Ashokan Missionaries:** Sent to Sri Lanka (**Mahinda and Sanghamitta**), Southeast Asia, and Central Asia.
- **Trade Routes:** Facilitated dissemination via the Silk Road and maritime routes.
- **Monastic Establishments:** Viharas and monasteries served as learning centers (e.g., Nalanda, Taxila).
- **Stupas and Chaityas:** Constructed as focal points of devotion and pilgrimage (e.g., Sanchi, Bharhut).
- **Art and Sculpture:** Gandhara and Mathura schools depicted Buddha and Jataka tales.
- **Adoption by Rulers:** Emperors like Ashoka and Kanishka actively patronized Buddhism.
- **Cultural Integration:** Assimilation with local traditions in Tibet, China, and Japan.

Jainism:

- **Southward Expansion:** Stronghold in Karnataka and Tamil Nadu regions.
- **Royal Patronage:** Kings like **Kharavela and Chalukyas** supported Jainism.
- **Architectural Marvels:** **Gomateshwara at Shravanabelagola, Dilwara Temples in Rajasthan.**
- **Trade Community:** Strong base among merchants for its emphasis on non-violence and ethics.
- **Textual Preservation:** **Valabhi Council** helped in codification and dissemination of texts.
- **Local Practices:** Integration with folk traditions and regional festivals.

Sects in Buddhism

Sect	Origin & Texts	Core Beliefs and Practices	Key Figures/Regions	Key Contributions/Legacy
Theravāda (Hinayana)	India; Pali Canon (Tipitaka)	Oldest tradition; focuses on individual liberation (Arhat path); strict adherence to original teachings of the Buddha.	Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand	Preserved original teachings of Buddha; Vipassana meditation practice; simplicity in rituals.
Mahayāna	India (1st Century CE); Sanskrit Sutras	Focus on universal salvation (Bodhisattva ideal), compassion for all beings, devotional practices.	China, Japan, Korea, Vietnam	Flourished Buddhist art, introduced new texts and concepts like emptiness (Śūnyatā) and Pure Land.

Sect	Origin & Texts	Core Beliefs and Practices	Key Figures/Regions	Key Contributions/Legacy
Vajrayāna (Tantrayana)	India (8th Century CE); Tantric Texts	Esoteric practices (mantras, mudras, mandalas, rituals); belief in rapid enlightenment; integration of Mahayana ideas.	Tibet, Bhutan, Mongolia	Developed Tibetan Buddhism; created a synthesis of Tantric and Mahayana elements.
Zen (Chan in China)	China (6th Century CE); Platform Sutra	Meditation-centric (Zazen); direct realization of enlightenment through experience; minimalistic rituals.	Japan, China	Influenced Japanese culture; art forms like Zen gardens, calligraphy, and martial arts philosophy.
Pure Land	India, spread to East Asia; Amitabha Sutra	Faith in Amitabha Buddha ; chanting of his name (Nianfo/Nembutsu) to ensure rebirth in the Pure Land (Sukhavati).	China, Japan, Korea	Popular devotional form of Buddhism; simplified practices for lay followers.
Nichiren	Japan (13th Century CE); Lotus Sutra	Chanting " Nam Myoho Renge Kyo " for enlightenment and worldly success; reformist and nationalistic approach in Japan.	Nichiren (Founder, Japan)	Advocated the supremacy of the Lotus Sutra; influenced modern organizations like Soka Gakkai.

Sects in Jainism

Sect	Origin & Texts	Core Beliefs and Practices	Key Figures/Regions	Key Contributions/Legacy
Digambara	Ancient India; scriptures mostly lost; Tattvartha Sutra	Strict asceticism, renunciation to the extent of nudity, belief that women cannot attain liberation without rebirth as men.	South India	Preserved early Jain tradition; focus on extreme renunciation and austerity.
Śvētāmbara	Ancient India; Agamas (canonical texts)	More inclusive; monks wear white robes; women can achieve liberation; emphasis on temple worship and textual study.	Gujarat, Rajasthan	Preserved and expanded Agamic literature ; liberal approach to asceticism.
Sthānakavāsī	15th Century CE; reformist Śvētāmbara sect	Opposes idol worship ; emphasizes meditation, self-purification, and simplicity in rituals.	Gujarat, Rajasthan	Advocated simple practices and meditation-centric approach.
Terāpanth	18th Century CE; reformist Śvētāmbara sect	Centralized leadership (Acharya system); strict discipline; focuses on ethics and self-restraint.	Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh	Structured and organized Jainism; promoted social reform and clarity in practices.
Yapaniya (Extinct)	Karnataka; merged Digambara and Śvētāmbara traditions	Flexible regarding dress codes; followed Śvētāmbara texts but Digambara ascetic practices.	Karnataka	Bridged sectarian divides; key role in early Jain history.

Comparison of Key Beliefs in Jainism's Sects

Aspect	Digambara	Śvētāmbara
Attire	Renunciation to nudity	White-clad monks and nuns.
Salvation for Women	Women cannot attain liberation in the same life.	Women can attain liberation.
Texts	Reject Śvētāmbara Agamas; rely on later compositions.	Accept Śvētāmbara Agamas as authentic.
Idol Worship	Prefer plain idols without adornments.	Use elaborately adorned idols in temples.
Practice	Emphasis on extreme asceticism.	Relatively lenient practices and inclusivity.

Contemporary Systems and Philosophies

Ajivikas

Aspect	Details
Founder	Makkhali Gosala
Key Beliefs	Strict determinism (Niyati), no role of karma or free will, emphasis on preordained destiny.
Practices	Severe asceticism, rejection of Vedic rituals, use of caves for meditation.
Texts	No surviving texts; details from Buddhist and Jain sources.
Regions	Prominent in Magadha and South India.
Legacy	Influenced ascetic traditions, but declined post-Mauryan era.

Charvaka (Lokayata)

Aspect	Details
Founder	Presumed Brihaspati (mythical), developed as a materialist philosophy.
Key Beliefs	Rejection of Vedas, atheism, hedonism, focus on material world and empirical evidence.
Practices	No asceticism, advocacy for enjoying life without fear of afterlife or rebirth.
Texts	Lost; details from opponents' texts like Manusmriti, Buddhist, and Jain critiques.
Regions	Urban centers like Magadha.
Legacy	Earliest materialist philosophy; influence on critical thinking and skepticism.

Ajñāna

Aspect	Details
Founder	Sanjaya Belatthaputta and others.
Key Beliefs	Skepticism; refusal to commit to any knowledge or belief system, including karma or liberation.
Practices	Emphasis on dialogue and questioning; rejection of absolute truths.
Texts	No known texts; recorded in Buddhist scriptures.
Regions	Magadha and Kosala.
Legacy	Contributed to intellectual discourse in ancient India.

Places Associated with Buddha

Place Name	Modern Location	Event/Association with Buddha	Key Details	Monuments/Artifacts
Lumbini	Rupandehi, Nepal	Birthplace of Buddha (563 BCE).	Queen Mahamaya gave birth to Siddhartha Gautama in the Lumbini Garden under a Sal tree.	Ashokan Pillar, Maya Devi Temple, ruins of monasteries.
Kapilavastu	Tilaurakot, Nepal	Childhood and early life of Siddhartha.	Capital of the Shakya kingdom, where Buddha spent his formative years as a prince.	Stupas, ruins of the royal palace, ancient fortifications.
Bodh Gaya	Bihar, India	Attained enlightenment under the Bodhi tree.	Siddhartha meditated for 49 days and became the Buddha.	Mahabodhi Temple, Bodhi Tree, Vajrasana (Diamond Throne).
Sarnath	Uttar Pradesh, India	First sermon (Dhammachakkappavattana Sutta).	Buddha preached the Four Noble Truths to five ascetics, marking the establishment of the Sangha.	Dhamek Stupa, Ashokan Pillar, ruins of monasteries, Sarnath Museum.
Rajagriha	Bihar, India	Frequent site of Buddha's teachings and early Sangha development.	Capital of Magadha under King Bimbisara, a patron of Buddha. Site of the First Buddhist Council.	Vulture's Peak, Bamboo Grove Monastery (Veluvana), ruins of ancient shrines.
Vaishali	Bihar, India	Buddha preached several discourses and announced his Parinirvana here.	Associated with the ordination of women into the Sangha.	Ashokan Pillar, Buddha Stupa, ruins of monasteries.
Kushinagar	Uttar Pradesh, India	Buddha attained Parinirvana (final death) at the age of 80.	Mahaparinirvana of Buddha after delivering his final teachings.	Parinirvana Stupa, reclining Buddha statue, Matha Kuar Shrine.
Shravasti	Uttar Pradesh, India	Site of many teachings and miracles of Buddha.	Buddha spent 24 rainy seasons here in Jetavana Monastery, performing the "Twin Miracle."	Jetavana Monastery ruins, Anathapindika's house remains, stupa remains.
Nalanda	Bihar, India	Buddha visited frequently and preached.	Became a major center of Buddhist learning in later years.	Ruins of Nalanda University, stupas, viharas.
Pataliputra	Bihar, India	Administrative center of Magadha Empire during Buddha's time.	Hosted early Buddhist councils and supported Buddhist propagation under Ashoka.	Mauryan-era remains, Ashokan stupas.
Gaya	Bihar, India	Pre-enlightenment penance and meditation site.	Buddha meditated and practiced asceticism before attaining enlightenment at Bodh Gaya.	Pre-Bodh Gaya ruins, Brahmayoni Hill caves.

Place Name	Modern Location	Event/Association with Buddha	Key Details	Monuments/Artifacts
Kosambi	Uttar Pradesh, India	Key site for monastic development and teachings.	Buddha stayed here during the rainy season; site of early Sangha conflicts.	Ghositarama Monastery ruins.
Sankasya	Uttar Pradesh, India	Believed to be the site of Buddha's descent from Tavatimsa heaven.	Buddha descended to Earth after preaching Abhidhamma to his mother in Tavatimsa heaven.	Ashokan Pillar remains, stupas.
Barabar Caves	Bihar, India	Used by Buddhist monks for meditation.	Oldest surviving rock-cut caves in India, patronized by Ashoka.	Lomas Rishi and Sudama Caves with inscriptions.
Mathura	Uttar Pradesh, India	Buddhist teachings and influence spread widely here.	Important center of Buddhist art and culture in early centuries.	Buddhist sculptures and stupas.
Uruvela	Bihar, India	Pre-enlightenment austerities practiced by Buddha.	Buddha practiced rigorous self-discipline before realizing the Middle Path.	Ancient meditation sites near Bodh Gaya.
Pavapuri	Bihar, India	Buddha preached before Parinirvana.	Site of one of his last sermons before heading to Kushinagar.	Ancient stupas, Jain temples (later era).
Devadaha	Nepal	Buddha's maternal home.	Siddhartha's birthplace and place of frequent visits during his early life.	Ruins of ancient settlements.
Rajayatana	Andhra Pradesh, India	Buddha stayed during his travel to South India.	Associated with spreading the Dhamma to southern regions.	Ruins of stupas and monasteries.
Pragbodhi	Bihar, India	Buddha meditated before enlightenment.	Cave where Buddha meditated and contemplated the futility of extreme asceticism.	Pragbodhi Cave remains.

Mauryan Edicts and Inscriptions

Types of Edicts

Type	Key Examples	Features and Themes
Pillar Edicts	Delhi-Topra, Sarnath	Dhamma propagation, moral teachings.
Rock Edicts	Dhauli, Girnar	Instructions on administration and justice.
Minor Rock Edicts	Maski, Brahmagiri	Ashoka's personal commitment to Dhamma.
Cave Inscriptions	Barabar Hills	Donations to Ajivikas, architectural details.

Notable Edicts

1. **Major Rock Edicts (14 Total):**
 - **Edict 1:** Prohibition of animal sacrifice.
 - **Edict 2:** Welfare of people, medical facilities for humans and animals.
 - **Edict 3:** Instructions on Dhamma officials (Dhamma Mahamattas).
 - **Edict 4:** Impact of Dhamma on society.
 - **Edict 5:** Appointment of Dhamma Mahamattas for welfare.
 - **Edict 6:** Transparency and access to the king for grievances.
 - **Edict 7:** Religious tolerance and harmony.
 - **Edict 8:** Personal tours promoting Dhamma.
 - **Edict 9:** Criticism of rituals; emphasis on moral practices.
 - **Edict 10:** Condemnation of fame-driven actions.
 - **Edict 11:** Charity, kindness, and moral duties.
 - **Edict 12:** Promotion of religious harmony.
 - **Edict 13:** Details Ashoka's remorse after Kalinga War and adoption of Dhamma.
 - **Edict 14:** Summary of all edicts.
2. **Minor Rock Edicts:**
 - Personal messages emphasizing Ashoka's conversion and support for Dhamma.
3. **Pillar Edicts (7 Total):**
 - Highlight Ashoka's policies and commitments to justice, moral governance, and animal welfare.

Architectural Aspects

- **Pillars:** Made of polished sandstone; topped with animal capitals (e.g., Lion Capital of Sarnath).
- **Caves:** Rock-cut caves for Ajivikas (e.g., Sudama Cave, Lomas Rishi Cave).
- **Inscription Style:** Prakrit in Brahmi and Kharosthi scripts.

Kushans, Satavahanas, Shakas, and Indo-Greeks: Contributions

Dynasty/Group	Key Rulers	Contributions to Art	Contributions to Culture	Contributions to Trade	Other Key Contributions
Kushanas	<i>Kanishka, Vasudeva, Kujula Kadphises</i>	- Patronage of Gandhara School of Art (Greco-Buddhist style). - Mathura School flourished. - Notable sculptures of Buddha and Bodhisattvas. - Coinage with realistic depictions of kings and deities.	- Spread of Mahayana Buddhism to Central Asia, China, and beyond. - Hosted the Fourth Buddhist Council in Kashmir. - Promoted Sanskrit literature and Buddhist texts. - Fusion of Indian and Hellenistic traditions.	- Controlled the Silk Road, linking India with China, Central Asia, and Rome. - Facilitated trade in silk, spices, and gemstones. - Issued gold coins, boosting economic stability.	- Introduced regnal years in inscriptions. - Encouraged medical research, with works like Charaka Samhita flourishing under Kanishka. - Played a significant role in cultural exchanges between India and Central Asia.
Satavahanas	<i>Gautamiputra Satakarni,</i>	- Development of Amaravati School	- Promoted Prakrit language	- Controlled key trade routes	- Fought against external threats

Dynasty/Group	Key Rulers	Contributions to Art	Contributions to Culture	Contributions to Trade	Other Key Contributions
	Pulumavi, Vasisthiputra Satakarni	of Art: Narrative reliefs and Buddhist stupas. - Construction of stupas and viharas, e.g., Amaravati, Nagarjunakonda. - Painted cave complexes like Ajanta (early phase).	for inscriptions and literary works. - Encouraged both Vedic traditions and Buddhism. - Sangam literature flourished in their period. - Issued coins with bilingual inscriptions (Prakrit and Dravidian languages).	between North and South India. - Major participants in Indo-Roman trade , exporting spices, ivory, and textiles. - Minted coins featuring ships, symbolizing maritime trade.	like Shakas. - Consolidated Deccan culture. - Promoted irrigation and agricultural development.
Shakas	Rudradaman I, Chashtana	- Promoted the construction of Junagarh Rock Inscription , detailing irrigation and governance. - Influenced local artistic styles in Gujarat and Rajasthan.	- Patronized Sanskrit literature: Rudradaman I was a Sanskrit scholar. - Encouraged cultural synthesis of Indian and Central Asian traditions. - Religious tolerance: Supported Buddhism, Jainism, and Vedic practices.	- Acted as intermediaries in trade between India, Rome, and Central Asia. - Promoted trade in horses, wine, and luxury goods. - Issued silver coins with high artistic standards.	- Developed irrigation projects, such as repairing the Sudarsana Lake. - Consolidated power in Gujarat, Malwa, and parts of Rajasthan. - Strengthened administration with a focus on law and order.
Indo-Greeks	Menander (Milinda), Demetrius, Agathocles	- Introduced Hellenistic art styles to India. - Early promoters of Greco-Buddhist Art , precursor to Gandhara art. - Coinage depicting deities like Zeus, Athena, and Indian deities like Vishnu and Shiva.	- Milinda Panha: A famous dialogue between King Menander and Buddhist monk Nagasena , promoting Buddhist philosophy. - Encouraged religious and cultural pluralism. - Blended Greek and Indian cultural	- Opened trade routes between India and the Mediterranean. - Encouraged commerce in wine, olive oil, and luxury goods. - Issued high-quality coins facilitating local and international trade.	- Helped disseminate Hellenistic knowledge in India. - Played a significant role in the initial fusion of Greek and Indian cultural elements, influencing later periods like the Kushanas.

Dynasty/Group	Key Rulers	Contributions to Art	Contributions to Culture	Contributions to Trade	Other Key Contributions
			elements in governance and society.		

Key Observations

- Art and Architecture:** All four groups significantly contributed to art, with the **Kushans excelling in Gandhara and Mathura schools, the Satavahanas in Amaravati art, the Shakas in inscriptions**, and the **Indo-Greeks in early Hellenistic influences**.
- Cultural Synthesis:** The Shakas and Indo-Greeks played pivotal roles in blending Central Asian, Greek, and Indian cultures, while the Satavahanas preserved local traditions alongside global influences.
- Trade:** Trade was a cornerstone of their economies, with the Kushans dominating the Silk Road, Satavahanas excelling in maritime trade, and the Shakas and Indo-Greeks promoting commerce across land and sea routes.
- Administrative Innovations:** The Kushans introduced regnal years, the Shakas focused on law and irrigation, and the Indo-Greeks emphasized efficient governance through cultural amalgamation.

Inscriptions Associated with Indo-Greeks, Kushans, Shakas, and Satavahanas

Dynasty	Inscription	Location	Language	Script	Key Features/Details	Significance
Indo-Greeks	Heliodorus Pillar	Vidisha (Besnagar), MP	Prakrit	Brahmi	Erected by Heliodorus, a Greek ambassador; mentions Vishnu (Garuda pillar).	Earliest evidence of Indo-Greek association with Hinduism.
	Milindapanho References	Sanchi and nearby sites	Pali	Brahmi	Text mentions King Menander (Milinda) and his conversion to Buddhism.	Highlights Greco-Buddhist interaction.
	Coin Inscriptions	Various Indo-Greek sites	Greek, Kharosthi	Greek, Kharosthi	Coins with legends of Demetrius, Menander, and Apollodotus in bilingual scripts.	Demonstrates Greek influence and local adaptation.
	Shinkot Inscription	Afghanistan	Greek	Greek	Mentions Indo-Greek rulers' governance.	Records administrative details.
	Ai-Khanoum Inscriptions	Ai-Khanoum, Afghanistan	Greek	Greek	Greek philosophical texts inscribed, reflecting Hellenistic culture .	Shows blend of Greek and Indian traditions.
Kushanas	Rabatak Inscription	Rabatak, Afghanistan	Bactrian	Greek-Bactrian	Mentions Kanishka, his genealogy, and promotion of Buddhism.	Crucial for reconstructing Kushana history.
	Mathura Inscriptions	Mathura, UP	Prakrit	Brahmi	Records donations to Buddhist monasteries under Kanishka and Huvishka.	Highlights patronage to Buddhism.

Dynasty	Inscription	Location	Language	Script	Key Features/Details	Significance
	Surkh Kotal Inscription	Surkh Kotal, Afghanistan	Bactrian	Greek-Bactrian	Mentions construction of fire temples under Kushana kings.	Reflects syncretism of Buddhist and Zoroastrian practices.
	Sarnath Buddha Image Inscription	Sarnath, UP	Prakrit	Brahmi	Refers to Kanishka's patronage of Buddhism.	Evidence of Buddhist art flourishing under Kushanas.
	Manikyala Stupa Inscriptions	Rawalpindi, Pakistan	Kharosthi	Kharosthi	Records donations to Buddhist stupas.	Reflects Kushana's Buddhist patronage.
Shakas	Junagarh Rock Inscription	Junagarh, Gujarat	Prakrit	Brahmi	Erected by Rudradaman ; details dam repairs of Sudarshana Lake.	First long inscription in classical Sanskrit.
	Andhau Inscription	Kutch, Gujarat	Sanskrit	Brahmi	Mentions a grant by Rudrasimha to Jain monks.	Highlights Jain patronage by Shakas.
	Nasik Cave Inscription	Nasik, Maharashtra	Prakrit	Brahmi	Records donations by Shaka satrap Nahapana for Buddhist monks.	Evidence of religious patronage.
	Karle Chaitya Inscription	Karle, Maharashtra	Prakrit	Brahmi	Refers to donations by Nahapana for the construction of a Buddhist Chaitya.	Reflects Shaka's role in Buddhist architecture .
	Sopara Inscription	Sopara, Maharashtra	Sanskrit	Brahmi	Mentions land grants by a Shaka ruler.	Evidence of administrative systems under Shakas.
Satavahanas	Nasik Cave Inscriptions	Nasik, Maharashtra	Prakrit	Brahmi	Records donations by Gautamiputra Satakarni and his mother Gautami Balashri .	Highlights Satavahana patronage of Buddhist architecture.
	Amaravati Stupa Inscription	Amaravati, Andhra Pradesh	Prakrit	Brahmi	Mentions donations by Satavahana kings to the Amaravati Stupa.	Evidence of Satavahana support for Buddhism.
	Nanaghat Inscriptions	Nanaghat, Maharashtra	Prakrit	Brahmi	Records the achievements and sacrifices of Satakarni and his queen Naganika.	Early record of Vedic sacrifices performed by Satavahanas.
	Karle Chaitya Inscriptions	Karle, Maharashtra	Prakrit	Brahmi	Refers to grants made by Satavahana kings for the Buddhist Chaitya.	Shows Satavahana role in Buddhist architecture.

Dynasty	Inscription	Location	Language	Script	Key Features/Details	Significance
	Junnar Inscriptions	Junnar, Maharashtra	Prakrit	Brahmi	Mentions donations by Satavahana kings and merchants.	Highlights trade and religious patronage.
	Kanheri Cave Inscription	Kanheri, Maharashtra	Prakrit	Brahmi	Records donations by Satavahana rulers for monastic establishments.	Reflects Satavahana support for Buddhist institutions.

Comparative Table: Gandhara, Mathura, and Amaravati Schools of Art

Aspect	Gandhara School	Mathura School	Amaravati School
Geographical Location	Northwest India and modern-day Pakistan (Peshawar, Taxila).	Mathura (Uttar Pradesh, India).	Andhra Pradesh (Amaravati, Nagarjunakonda).
Time Period	1st Century BCE to 4th Century CE.	2nd Century BCE to 12th Century CE (peaked under Kushanas).	2nd Century BCE to 4th Century CE.
Cultural Influences	Strong Greco-Roman influence due to Hellenistic contact.	Indigenous Indian style with minimal external influence.	Indigenous with Satavahana influence.
Materials Used	Gray schist and green phyllite stone.	Red sandstone.	White marble and limestone.
Depictions of Buddha	Realistic, human-like, with detailed drapery resembling Roman togas.	Iconic with spiritual calm, seated or standing Buddha, minimal drapery.	Dynamic, narrative-style reliefs showing stories from Buddha's life.
Key Features	- Wavy hair.	- Simpler facial expressions.	- Intricate carvings.
	- Prominent musculature.	- Round face with fleshy cheeks.	- More focus on storytelling.
	- Detailed folds of drapery.	- Shorter drapery, lighter folds.	- Figures in high relief.
	- Realistic anatomy.	- Stylized anatomy.	- Crowded compositions.
Themes	- Buddha's life and Jataka tales.	- Buddha as a divine figure and yakshas/yakshis.	- Jataka tales and scenes from Buddha's life.
Religious Symbols	Hellenistic motifs such as vine scrolls, Corinthian columns.	Lotus and chakra motifs, yaksha imagery.	Depictions of Bodhi tree, stupas, and medallions.
Expression and Style	Naturalistic and elegant.	Idealistic and spiritual.	Emotional and narrative-driven.
Prominent Patrons	Kushanas (Kanishka).	Kushanas and Guptas.	Satavahanas and Ikshvakus.
Key Sites	Taxila, Peshawar.	Mathura, Sarnath.	Amaravati, Nagarjunakonda.
Legacy	Fusion of Indian and Greco-Roman art styles; influenced later Buddhist art in Central Asia.	Foundation of Indian iconography, influencing Gupta art.	Known for narrative-driven style, influenced Southeast Asian art.

Sangam Age and Sangam Literature

Aspect	Details
Time Period	Roughly 300 BCE to 300 CE (approx. 600 years).
Geographical Region	Tamil Nadu, parts of Kerala, and southern Karnataka.
Key Sources	Sangam literature, Tamil Brahmi inscriptions, Megasthenes' accounts, and archaeological findings.
Political Structure	Tribes and kingdoms under Chieftains or Kings (Moovendars).
Three Crowned Kings (Moovendars)	Chola, Chera, and Pandya dynasties.
Major Kingdoms	Cholas: Kaveripattinam; Cheras: Vanji (Karur); Pandyas: Madurai.
Economy	Agriculture (rice, spices, and cotton); maritime trade with Rome, Southeast Asia, and Sri Lanka.
Social Life	Varna-like Structure: Not rigid; Women's Role: Poets, warriors, respect for chastity (Kannagi- Chilappathikaram)
Religious Beliefs	Worship of nature (Murugan, Kotravai, Mayon), ancestor worship, and megalithic burial practices.
Language	Old Tamil; highly developed grammar and vocabulary. - Chentamil
Key Assemblies	Sangams: Literary assemblies in Madurai; 3 Sangams in total.

Sangam Literature: Features and Contributions

Aspect	Details
Name	Sangam Literature
Compiled In	Madurai; during the three Sangams (First, Second, and Third).
Nature	Secular; focused on themes like love, war, ethics, and nature.
Major Divisions	Aham (Inner/Personal): Love and emotions, Spirituality; Puram (Outer/Public): War, valor, and ethics.
Classification	Ettuthokai (Eight Anthologies) and Pathupattu (Ten Idylls).
Grammar Work	Tolkappiyam: Authored by Tolkappiyar; oldest extant Tamil grammar text.
Poetic Style	Akam-Puram dichotomy, brevity, rich metaphors, alliteration, and strict metrical structures.

Key Works in Sangam Literature

Category	Texts	Themes and Features
Ettuthokai	1. Aingurunooru	500 poems on love (Akam).
	2. Akananuru	400 poems on Akam themes (love, relationships).
	3. Purananuru	400 poems on Puram themes (war, valor, ethics).
	4. Kurunthogai	Short poems on Akam and Puram themes.
	5. Natrinai	400 poems; focus on Akam themes.
	6. Pathitruvalu	Praise of Chera kings (Puram).
	7. Paripadal	Poems on gods (Murugan, Vishnu).

Category	Texts	Themes and Features
Pathupattu	8. Kalithogai	Love poems; unique kalippa meter.
	1. Tirumurugarruppadai	Guide to worship Murugan.
	2. Porunaratruppadai	Describes generous patron-kings.
	3. Perumpanarruppadai	Depicts Pandya kings and their valor.
	4. Sirrupanarruppadai	Mentions life of ordinary people.
	5. Mullaippattu	Landscape-based poem (Mullai: Forest).
	6. Nedunalvatai	Winter description; Akam context.
	7. Kurinjpattu	Love and fertility; kurinji landscape.
	8. Maduraikkanchi	Describes Madurai; political and cultural significance.
	9. Pattinappalai	Coastal trade and urban life (Puhar).
	10. Malaiyapattu	Praise of mountains and their rulers.

Sangam Society

Aspect	Details
Family	Joint family system; importance of women in social life.
Occupation	Agriculture, fishing, weaving, pearl diving, and trade.
Education	Importance of poetry and music; literacy among elites.
Food and Dress	Rice, meat, toddy; cotton and silk clothing.
Festivals	Karthigai festival for Murugan; seasonal and harvest celebrations.

Key Archaeological Evidence of Sangam Age

Site	Region	Findings
Keeladi	Tamil Nadu	Urban settlement with advanced drainage and pottery.
Arikamedu	Tamil Nadu	Roman artifacts; evidence of Indo-Roman trade.
Kodumanal	Tamil Nadu	Semi-precious stones and iron implements; proof of industry.
Puhar (Kaveripattinam)	Tamil Nadu	Trade center, mentions in Pattinappalai .
Alagankulam	Tamil Nadu	Evidence of Roman amphorae and coins.
Adichanallur	Tamil Nadu	Burial urns, megalithic remains, and inscriptions in Tamil-Brahmi script .

Trade and Economy

Aspect	Details
Internal Trade	Local markets; barter system; agricultural surplus exchange.
External Trade	Flourished with Rome (gold, pearls, spices), Southeast Asia, and China.
Ports	Puhar (Cholas), Muziris (Cheras), Korkai (Pandyas).
Roman Coins	Found in large quantities, indicating active Indo-Roman trade.

Religion and Beliefs

Aspect	Details
Gods Worshipped	Murugan (war and fertility), Kotravai (goddess of victory), Mayon (Vishnu), and others.
Rituals	Megalithic burials; ancestor worship.
Sacred Landscapes	Kurinji (mountain), Mullai (forest), Marutham (plains), Neithal (coast), Palai (desert).

Key Contributions

Aspect	Details
Cultural Legacy	High literary and artistic achievements; influences later Tamil literature.
Political Legacy	Foundation for later kingdoms like the Pallavas and Cholas.
Art and Music	Contributions to classical Tamil music and dance forms (Bharatanatyam).
Historical Importance	Earliest record of Dravidian culture; Sangam texts are a treasure trove for history.

Gupta Empire (Up to 5th Century CE)

Administration

Aspect	Details
Political Structure	Monarchical with decentralized power; local autonomy was granted to vassal states and feudal lords. Kings maintained control over external affairs while local rulers handled administration.
Titles of Kings	Kings adopted grand titles like <i>Maharajadhiraja</i> (Great King of Kings), <i>Parameshvara</i> (Supreme Lord), <i>Paramabhattacharaka</i> (Exalted Lord), and <i>Chakravartin</i> (Universal Monarch).
Territorial Extent	Empire stretched from the Gangetic plains to parts of western India, northern Deccan, and Bengal. Key territories included Magadha, Malwa, and Gujarat.
Capital	Pataliputra (modern-day Patna) as the main capital; secondary capitals included Ujjain (Malwa region) and Prayaga (modern Allahabad).
Provinces	Divided into <i>Bhuktis</i> (provinces), governed by <i>Uparikas</i> (provincial governors) appointed by the king.
Districts	Bhuktis were subdivided into <i>Vishayas</i> (districts), administered by <i>Vishayapatis</i> with the help of local representatives.
Villages	Village-level administration was under the <i>Gramika</i> (village headman); <i>Samiti</i> (village assemblies) played a significant role in local governance.
Revenue Administration	Land revenue (Bhaga: usually 1/4th or 1/6th of agricultural produce); additional taxes on water usage, trade, crafts, and salt.
Military	Well-organized army with a strong cavalry (emphasized as key to success), infantry, war elephants, and chariots. Alliance with feudal lords provided auxiliary forces.

Aspect	Details
Espionage	A well-developed spy network (Gupta intelligence system) for maintaining internal security and monitoring officials and territories.
Judiciary	Administered based on <i>Dharmashastras</i> and customary laws; king acted as the highest court of appeal. Civil and criminal laws were distinct, and punishments were often lenient.
Feudal System	Emergence of feudalism as land grants (Agrahara) were given to Brahmins and officials in lieu of salaries, creating dependency on local rulers.
Law Enforcement	Officials like <i>Mahadandanayaka</i> (chief justice) and <i>Dandapashika</i> (police chief) maintained law and order.

Cultural Contributions

Aspect	Details
Religion	Revival of Brahmanical Hinduism; Vishnu, Shiva, and Shakti worship flourished. Vaishnavism became dominant, but Buddhism and Jainism were patronized.
Temple Architecture	Development of <i>Nagara style</i> temples with shikharas and mandapas; early examples include Dashavatara Temple (Deogarh) and Bhitargaon Temple (Kanpur).
Cave Architecture	Ajanta and Ellora caves flourished under Gupta patronage, depicting Buddhist themes, Jataka tales, and intricate carvings.
Sculpture	Mastery in stone, bronze, and terracotta sculptures; Sarnath's Buddha statue (Gupta style) reflects simplicity, grace, and serenity.
Painting	Ajanta cave frescoes portrayed Jataka tales, royal life, and nature. Use of natural dyes, vivid colors, and dynamic expressions.
Language	Sanskrit became the lingua franca of administration and literature. <i>Prakrit</i> and regional dialects flourished for local communication.
Literature	- Kalidasa's works: <i>Shakuntala</i> , <i>Raghuvamsha</i> , <i>Meghaduta</i> - Sudraka's <i>Mricchakatika</i> (Little Clay Cart), Bhasa's dramas, and Vishakhadatta's <i>Mudrarakshasa</i> .
Education	Universities like Nalanda, Taxila, and Vallabhi thrived. Education focused on Vedic texts, astronomy, mathematics, logic, and medicine.
Philosophy	Philosophical schools like Vedanta, Mimamsa, Nyaya, and Sankhya flourished; Buddhism evolved into Mahayana and Vajrayana schools.
Music and Dance	Development of classical music (<i>Samgita</i>) and dance forms. Bharata's <i>Natya Shastra</i> codified the principles of drama and performing arts.
Festivals	Festivals like Holi, Diwali, and Navaratri gained prominence, emphasizing Hindu rituals and social bonding.

Science and Technology

Field	Contributions
Astronomy	Aryabhata's <i>Aryabhatiya</i> introduced concepts of heliocentrism, Earth's rotation, value of pi, and eclipses.
Mathematics	Decimal system and zero formalized; Aryabhata's contributions to trigonometry and algebra; Brahmagupta's work on quadratic equations and arithmetic progression.
Medicine	Sushruta's <i>Samhita</i> (surgery and anatomy); Charaka's <i>Samhita</i> (internal medicine); advanced surgical tools and herbal treatments.

Field	Contributions
Metallurgy	Delhi Iron Pillar (7m tall, rust-resistant iron technology); advancements in steel-making and metal casting.
Engineering	Innovations in water management systems (canals, tanks, and wells); urban planning and fortifications.
Agriculture	Introduction of crop rotation, improved irrigation systems, and use of plows with iron tips.
Textiles	Gupta textiles (silk, muslin, cotton) were highly valued; famous centers of production exported to Rome, China, and Southeast Asia.
Chemistry	Advanced understanding of dyeing, glass-making, and chemical processes like distillation.

Other Contributions

Aspect	Details
Trade and Commerce	Thriving domestic and international trade via the Silk Road and Indian Ocean; exported spices, textiles, ivory, and pearls.
Coins and Currency	Issued gold coins (<i>Dinaras</i>), silver coins, and copper coins depicting kings, deities, and artistic motifs.
Economic Prosperity	Agrarian-based economy with flourishing guild systems (<i>Shrenis</i>) for artisans, merchants, and craftsmen.
Maritime Activities	Ports like Tamralipti, Bharuch, and Sopara connected Gupta India to Southeast Asia, China, and the Middle East.
Social Structure	Varna system remained dominant; land-owning Brahmins and Kshatriyas held power; rise of merchant guilds in the economy.
Women's Status	Women enjoyed some rights, especially in upper classes (education and property); however, patriarchal norms prevailed.
Sports and Recreation	Chess (<i>Chaturanga</i>), dice games, hunting, and archery were popular leisure activities.
Artistic Achievements	Integration of art into coins, temples, and public spaces; emphasis on grace and symmetry in Gupta art.
Foreign Relations	Diplomatic ties with Rome, Persia, and Southeast Asia; ambassadors like Fa-Hien documented Gupta governance, society, and economy.

Ancient Indian Philosophical Schools

Ancient Indian Philosophical Schools, categorized into **Astika (Orthodox)** and **Nastika (Heterodox)** schools.

Astika (Orthodox) Schools

These schools accept the authority of the **Vedas**.

School	Founder/Key Figures	Text/Scriptures	Core Philosophy	Key Features
Nyaya	Gautama (Akshapada)	Nyaya Sutras	Logic and reasoning as the path to liberation.	- Focus on Pramana (means of knowledge): Perception, Inference, Comparison, and Verbal Testimony. - Goal: Liberation through knowledge of reality.

School	Founder/Key Figures	Text/Scriptures	Core Philosophy	Key Features
Vaisheshika	Kanada (Ulooka)	Vaisheshika Sutras	Atomism: Everything is composed of anu (atoms) .	- Six categories (Padarthas): Substance, Quality, Action, Generality, Particularity, and Inherence. - Materialistic ontology.
Samkhya	Kapila	Samkhya Karika	Dualistic: Purusha (spirit) and Prakriti (matter).	- Explains creation through the interaction of Purusha and Prakriti. - Three Gunas: Sattva, Rajas, Tamas.
Yoga	Patanjali	Yoga Sutras	Control of the mind and body to attain liberation (Samadhi).	- Eightfold Path (Ashtanga Yoga): Yama, Niyama, Asana, Pranayama, Pratyahara, Dharana, Dhyana, Samadhi.
Purva Mimamsa	Jaimini	Mimamsa Sutras	Rituals and dharma are central; focus on Karma Kanda of the Vedas.	- Emphasis on Vedic sacrifices and duties. - Apurva: Link between ritual and its result.
Vedanta (Uttara Mimamsa)	Badarayana (Vyasa)	Brahma Sutras, Upanishads	Non-dual (Advaita), Dual (Dvaita), and Qualified Non-Dual (Vishishtadvaita) views.	- Focus on Brahman (ultimate reality) and Atman. - Liberation through knowledge, devotion, or meditation.

Nastika (Heterodox) Schools

These schools reject the authority of the **Vedas**.

School	Founder/Key Figures	Text/Scriptures	Core Philosophy	Key Features
Charvaka (Lokayata)	Brihaspati (Attributed)	No canonical texts	Materialism and hedonism: Focus on tangible reality and rejection of afterlife.	- Denial of karma, rebirth, and liberation. - Empiricism: Only perception (Pratyaksha) as valid knowledge.
Buddhism	Gautama Buddha	Tripitaka, Mahayana Sutras	Four Noble Truths and Eightfold Path to attain Nirvana.	- Middle Path between asceticism and indulgence. - Key branches: Theravada, Mahayana, Vajrayana.
Jainism	Mahavira (24th Tirthankara)	Agamas	Liberation through non-violence (Ahimsa), truth, and self-discipline.	- Five Vows: Ahimsa, Satya, Asteya, Brahmacharya, Aparigraha. - Syadvada (Anekantavada): Pluralism.
Ajivika	Makkhali Gosala	No surviving texts	Determinism: Everything is preordained; no free will.	- Denial of karma and soul's autonomy. - Promoted ascetic lifestyle with emphasis on destiny (Niyati).

Key Concepts Across Schools

Concept	Definition	Schools Associated
Pramana (Means of Knowledge)	Valid ways to acquire knowledge (e.g., perception, inference, comparison, testimony).	Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Vedanta, Samkhya.
Purusha-Prakriti	Dualistic components of reality: spirit (Purusha) and matter (Prakriti).	Samkhya, Yoga.
Ahimsa (Non-Violence)	Principle of not causing harm to any living being.	Jainism, Buddhism, Vedanta.
Karma and Rebirth	Actions in life determine future birth and experiences.	Vedanta, Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa.
Brahman and Atman	Ultimate reality (Brahman) and individual self (Atman).	Vedanta.
Four Noble Truths	Core Buddhist teachings on suffering, its cause, cessation, and path to liberation.	Buddhism.
Dharma	Righteous duty, law, or moral order.	Mimamsa, Vedanta, Buddhism, Jainism.

PREVIOUS YEAR UPSC QUESTIONS

1. In which one of the following regions was Dhanyakataka, which flourished as a prominent Buddhist centre under the Mahasanghikas, located?

- (a) Andhra
- (b) Gandhara
- (c) Kalinga
- (d) Magadha

2. With reference to ancient India, consider the following statements :

1. The concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin.
2. Stupa was generally a repository of relics.
3. Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

3. With reference to ancient South India, Korkai, Poompuhar and Muchiri were well known as

- (a) capital cities
- (b) ports
- (c) centres of iron-and-steel making
- (d) shrines of Jain Tirthankaras

4. Which one of the following explains the practice of Vattakirutal' as mentioned in Sangam poems?

- (a) Kings employing women bodyguards.
- (b) Learned persons assembling in royal courts to discuss religious and philosophical matters
- (c) Young girls keeping watch over agricultural fields and driving away birds and animals
- (d) A king defeated in a battle committing ritual suicide by starving himself to death

5. Consider the following dynasties:

1. Hoysala
2. Gahadavala
3. Kakatiya
4. Yadava

How many of the above dynasties established their kingdoms in early eighth century AD?

- (a) Only one

- (b) Only two
(c) Only three
(d) None

6. With reference to ancient Indian History, consider the following pairs:

	Literary work	Author
1.	Devichandragupta	Bilhana
2.	Hammira-Mahakavya	Nayachandra Suri
3.	Milinda-panha	Nagarjuna
4.	Nitivakyamrita	Somadeva Suri

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

- (a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) Only three
(d) All four

7. "Souls are not only the property of animal and plant life, but also of rocks, running water and many other natural objects not looked on as living by other religious sects."

The above statement reflects one of the core beliefs of which one of the following religious sects of ancient India?

- (a) Buddhism
(b) Jainism
(c) Shaivism
(d) Vaishnavism

8. Who among the following rulers of Vijayanagara Empire constructed a large dam across Tungabhadra River and canalcum-aqueduct several kilometres long from the river to the capital city?

- (a) Devaraya I**
(b) Mallikarjuna
(c) Vira Vijaya
(d) Virupaksha

9. Consider the following pairs:

	Site	Well known for
1.	Besnagar	Shaivite cave shrine
2.	Bhaja	Buddhist cave shrine
3.	Sittanawasal	Jain cave shrine

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

- (a) Only one
(b) Only two
(c) All three
(d) None

2022

1. Consider the following pairs:

	Site of Ashoka's major rock edicts		Location in the State of
1.	Dhauili	—	Odisha
2.	Erragudi	—	Andhra Pradesh
3.	Jaugada	—	Madhya Pradesh
4.	Kalsi	—	Karnataka

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) Only one pair
- (b) Only two pairs**
- (c) Only three pairs
- (d) All four pairs

2. Which one of the following statement about Sangam literature in ancient South India is correct?

- (a) Sangam poems are devoid of any reference to material culture.
- (b) The social classification of Varna was known to Sangam poets.**
- (c) Sangam poems have no reference to warrior ethic.
- (d) Sangam literature refers to magical forces as irrational.

3. "Yogavasistha" was translated into Persian by Nizamuddin Panipati during the reign of:

- (a) Akbar**
- (b) Humayun
- (c) Shahjahan
- (d) Aurangzeb

4. The world's second tallest statue in sitting pose of Ramanuja was inaugurated by the Prime Minister of India at Hyderabad recently. Which one of the following statements correctly represents the teachings of Ramanuja?

- (a) The best means of salvation was devotion.**
- (b) Vedas are eternal, self-existent and wholly authoritative.
- (c) Logical arguments were essential means for the highest bliss
- (d) Salvation was to be obtained through meditation.

5. The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at Veraval. Which of the following statements are correct regarding Somnath Temple?

- 1. Somnath Temple is one of the Jyotirlinga shrines.
- 2. A description of Somnath Temple was given by Al-Biruni.
- 3. Pran Pratishtha of Somnath Temple (installation of the present day temple) was done by President S. Radhakrishnan.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only**
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

6. With reference to Indian history, consider the following texts:

- 1. Nettipakarana
- 2. Parishishtaparvan
- 3. Avadanashataka

4. Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana
Which of the above are Jaina texts?

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2 and 4 only**
- (c) 1, 3 and 4
- (d) 2, 3 and 4

7. With reference to Indian history, consider the following pairs:

	Historical person		Known as
1.	Aryadeva	—	Jaina scholar
2.	Dignaga	—	Buddhist scholar
3.	Nathamuni	—	Vaishnava scholar

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) None of the pairs
- (b) Only one pair
- (c) Only two pairs**
- (d) All three pairs

8. According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, which of the following are correct?

- 1. A person could be a slave as a result of a judicial punishment.
- 2. If a female slave bore her master a son, she was legally free.
- 3. If a son born to a female slave was fathered by her master, the son was entitled to the legal status of the master's son.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3**

2021

1. Which one of the following ancient towns is well-known for its elaborate system of water harvesting and management by building a series of dams and channelizing water into connected reservoirs?

- (a) Dholavira**
- (b) Kalibangan
- (c) Rakhigarhi
- (d) Ropar

2. From the decline of Guptas until the rise of Harshavardhana in the early seventh century, which of the following kingdoms were holding power in Northern India?

- 1. The Guptas of Magadha
- 2. The Paramaras of Malwa
- 3. The Pushyabhutis of Thanesar
- 4. The Maukharis of Kanauj
- 5. The Yadavas of Devagiri
- 6. The Maitrakas of Valabhi

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1, 2 and 5 only
- (b) 1, 3, 4 and 6 only**
- (c) 2, 3 and 4 only

(d) 5 and 6 only

3. With reference to the history of ancient India, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. Mitakshara was the civil law for upper castes and Dayabhaga was the civil law for lower castes.
2. In the Mitakshara system, the sons can claim right to the property during the lifetime of the father, whereas in the Dayabhaga system, it is only after the death of the father that the sons can claim right to the property.
3. The Mitakshara system deals with the matters related to the property held by male members only of a family, whereas the Dayabhaga system deals with the matters related to the property held by both male and female members of a family.

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1 and 2
(b) 2 only
(c) 1 and 3
(d) 3 only

4. With reference to India, the terms 'Halbi, Ho and Kui' pertain to

- (a) Dance forms of Northwest India
(b) Musical instruments
(c) Pre-historic cave paintings
(d) Tribal languages

5. With reference to the history of ancient India, Bhavabhuti, Hastimalla and Kshemeshvara were famous

- (a) Jain monks
(b) Playwrights
(c) Temple architects
(d) Philosophers

6. Which one of the following statements is correct?

- (a) Ajanta Caves lie in the gorge of Waghora River.
(b) Sanchi Stupa lies in the gorge of Chambal River.
(c) Pandu-lena Cave Shrines lie in the gorge of Narmada River.
(d) Amaravati Stupa lies in the gorge of Godavari River.

7. With reference to Chausath Yogini Temple situated near Morena, consider the following statements:

1. It is a circular temple built during the reign of Kachchhapaghata Dynasty.
2. It is the only circular temple built in India.
3. It was meant to promote the Vaishnava cult in the region.
4. Its design has given rise to a popular belief that it was the inspiration behind the Indian Parliament building.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 4 only
(d) 2, 3 and 4 only

8. Consider the following pairs:

	Historical place	Well-known for
1.	Burzahom	Rock-cut shrines
2.	Chandraketugarh	Terracotta art
3.	Ganeshwar	Copper artefacts

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 2 and 3 only**

2020

1. With reference to the scholars/litterateurs of ancient India, consider the following statements:

- 1. Panini is associated with Pushyamitra
- 2. Amarasimha is associated with Harshavardhana
- 3. Kalidasa is associated with Chandra Gupta-II

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 3 only**
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

2. With reference to the history of India, consider the following pairs:

1.	Aurang	-	In-charge of treasury of the State
2.	Banian	-	Indian agent of the East India Company
3.	Mirasidar	-	Designated revenue payer to the State

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

3. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements:

- 1. Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism.
- 2. Lokottaravadin sect was an offshoot of Mahasanghika sect of Buddhism.
- 3. The deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana Buddhism.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

4. Consider the following events in the history of India:

- 1. Rise of Pratiharas under King Bhoja
- 2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman-I
- 3. Establishment of Chola power by Parantaka-I
- 4. Pala dynasty founded by Gopala

What is the correct chronological order of the above events, starting from the earliest time?

- (a) 2 – 1 – 4 – 3
- (b) 3 – 1 – 4 – 2
- (c) 2 – 4 – 1 – 3**
- (d) 3 – 4 – 1 – 2

5. Which of the following phrases defines the nature of the 'Hundi' generally referred to in the sources of the post-Harsha period?

- (a) An advisory issued by the king to his subordinates

- (b) A diary to be maintained for daily accounts
(c) A bill of exchange
 (d) An order from the feudal lord to his subordinates

6. With reference to the history of India, the terms 'kulyavapa' and 'dronavapa' denote

- (a) measurement of land**
 (b) coins of different monetary value
 (c) classification of urban land
 (d) religious rituals

7. Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription?

"Whosoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect very severely."

- (a) Ashoka**
 (b) Samundragupta
 (c) Harshavardhana
 (d) Krishnadeva Raya

8. With reference to the history of India, consider the following pairs:

	Famous Place		Present State
1.	Bhilsa	-	Madhya Pradesh
2.	Dwarasamudra	-	Maharashtra
3.	Girinagar	-	Gujarat
4.	Sthanesvara	-	Uttar Pradesh

Which of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 3 only**
 (b) 1 and 4 only
 (c) 2 and 3 only
 (d) 2 and 4 only

9. With reference to the period of Gupta dynasty in ancient India, the towns Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were known as

- (a) ports handling foreign trade**
 (b) capitals of powerful kingdoms
 (c) places of exquisite stone art and architecture
 (d) important of Buddhist pilgrimage centers

10. With reference to the cultural history of India, which one of the following is the correct description of the term 'paramitas'?

- (a) The earliest Dharmashastra texts written in aphoristic (sutra) style
 (b) Philosophical schools that did not accept the authority of Vedas
(c) Perfections whose attainment led to the Bodhisattva path
 (d) Powerful merchant guilds of early medieval South India

11. With reference to the cultural history of India, consider the following pairs:

1.	Parivrajaka	-	Renunciant and Wanderer
2.	Shramana	-	Priest with a high status

3.	Upasaka	-	Lay follower of Buddhism
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Which of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only**
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

2019

1. Which one of the following is not a Harappan site?

- (a) Chanhudaro
- (b) Kot Diji
- (c) Sohgauna**
- (d) Desalpur

2. In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka) mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka?

- (a) Kanganahalli**
- (b) Sanchi
- (c) Shahbazgrhi
- (d) Sohgauna

3. Consider the following:

1. Deification of the Buddha
2. Treading the path of Bodhisattvas
3. Image worship and rituals

Which of the above is/are the feature/ features of Mahayana Buddhism?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3**

4. With reference to forced labour (Vishti) in India during the Gupta period, which one of the following statements is correct?

- (a) It was considered a source of income for the State, a sort of tax paid by the people.**
- (b) It was totally absent in the Madhya Pradesh and Kathiawar regions of the Gupta Empire.
- (c) The forced labourer was entitled to weekly wages.
- (d) The eldest son of the labourer was sent as the forced labourer.

5. Building 'Kalyana Mandapas' was a notable feature in the temple construction in the kingdom of

- (a) Chalukya
- (b) Chandela
- (c) Rashtrakuta
- (d) Vijayanagara**

2018

1. Consider the following pairs:

Tradition — State

1. Chapchar Kut Festival — Mizoram
2. Khongjom Parba ballad — Manipur
3. Thang-Ta Dance — Sikkim

Which of the pairs given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only**

(b) 1 and 2

(c) 1 and 2

(d) 2 and 3

2. With reference to culture history of India, consider the following statements:

1. Most of the Tyagaraja Kritis are devotional songs in praise of Lord Krishna.
2. Tyagaraja created several new ragas.
3. Annamacharya and Tyagaraja are contemporaries.
4. Annamacharya kirtanas are devotional songs in praise of Lord Venketshwara.

Which of the statement is given above are correct?

(a) 1 and 3 only

(b) 2 and 4 only

(c) 1, 2 and 3

(d) 2, 3 and 4

3. With reference to the cultural history of India, consider the following statements:

1. White marble was used in making Buland Darwaza and Khankah at Fatehpur Sikri.
2. Red Sandstone and marble were used in making Bara Imambara and Rumi Darwaza in Lucknow.

Which of the following statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 only

(c) Both 1 and 2

(d) Neither 1 nor 2

4. With reference to the Indian History, who among the following is a future Buddha, yet to come to save the world?

(a) Avalokiteshvara

(b) Lokeshvara

(c) Maitreya

(d) Padmapani

5. The well-known painting "Bani Thani" belongs to the

(a) Bundi school

(b) Jaipur school

(c) Kangra school

(d) Kishangarh school

6. With reference to the religious practices in India, the "Sthanakvasi" sect belongs to

(a) Buddhism

(b) Jainism

(c) Vaishnavism

(d) Shaivism

2017

1. With reference to the difference between the culture of Rigvedic Aryans and Indus Valley people, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. Rigvedic Aryans used the coat of mail and helmet in warfare whereas the people of Indus Valley Civilization did not leave any evidence of using them.
2. Rigvedic Aryans knew gold, silver and copper whereas Indus Valley people knew only copper and iron.
3. Rigvedic Aryans had domesticated the horse whereas there is no evidence of Indus Valley people having been aware of this animal.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 and 3 only

(c) 1 and 3 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

2. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements:

1. Sautrantika and Sammitiya were the sects of Jainism.
2. Sarvastivadin held that the constituents of phenomena were not wholly momentary, but existed forever in a latent form.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
 (c) Both 1 and 2
 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

3. Which one of the following was a very important seaport in the Kakatiya kingdom?

- (a) Kakinada
(b) Motupalli
 (c) Machilipatnam (Masulipatnam)
 (d) Nelluru

4. The painting of Bodhisattva Padmapani is one of the most famous and oft-illustrated paintings at:

- (a) Ajanta**
 (b) Badami
 (c) Bagh
 (d) Ellora

5. Consider the following pairs:

	Traditions	Communities
1	Chaliha Sahib Festival	Sindhis
2	Nanda Raj Jaat Yatra	Gonds
3	Wari-Warkari	Santhals

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only**
 (b) 2 and 3 only
 (c) 1 and 3 only
 (d) None of the above

6. Which of the following is/are famous for Sun temples?

1. Arasavalli
2. Amarakantak
3. Omkareshwar

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only**
 (b) 2 and 3 only
 (c) 1 and 3 only
 (d) 1, 2 and 3

7. With reference to Manipuri Sankirtana, consider the following statements:

1. It is a song and dance performance.
2. Cymbals are the only musical instruments used in the performance.
3. It is performed to narrate the life and deeds of Lord Krishna.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 1 and 3 only**
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1 only

2016

1. In the context of the history of India, consider the following pairs:

Term Description

1. Eripatti Land, revenue from which was set apart for the maintenance of the village tank
2. Taniyurs Villages donated to a single Brahmin or a group of Brahmins
3. Ghatikas Colleges generally attached to the temples

Which of the pairs given above correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3
- (d) 1 and 3**

2. With reference to the cultural history of India, the memorizing of chronicles, dynastic histories and epic tales was the profession of who of the following?

- (a) Shramana
- (b) Parivrajaka
- (c) Agrahaarika
- (d) Maagadha**

3. Who of the following had first deciphered the edicts of Emperor Ashoka?

- (a) Georg Buhler
- (b) James Prinsep**
- (c) Max Muller
- (d) William Jones

4. Which one of the following books of ancient India has the love story of the son of the founder of Sunga dynasty?

- (a) Swapnavasavadatta
- (b) Malavikagnimitra**
- (c) Meghadoota
- (d) Ratnavali

5. With reference to the cultural history of medieval India, consider the following statements:

1. Siddhas (Sittars) of Tamil region were monotheistic and condemned idolatry.
2. Lingayats of Kannada region questioned the theory of rebirth and rejected the caste hierarchy.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2**
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

6. Who of the following had first deciphered the edicts of Emperor Ashoka?

- (a) Georg Buhler
- (b) James Prinsep**
- (c) Max Muller
- (d) William Jones

7. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements:

1. The concept of Bodhisattva is central to Hinayana sect of Buddhism.
2. Bodhisattva is a compassionate one on his way to enlightenment.

3. Bodhisattva delays achieving his own salvation to help all sentient beings on their path to it.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 2 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

8. What is/are common to the two historical places known as Ajanta and Mahabalipuram?

- 1. Both were built in the same period.
- 2. Both belong to the same religious denomination.
- 3. Both have rock-cut monuments.

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1 and 2 only**
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) None of the statements given above is correct

9. In the context of the history of India, consider the following pairs:

Term Description

- 1. Eripatti : Land, revenue from which was set apart for the maintenance of the village tank
- 2. Taniyurs : Villages donated to a single Brahmin or a group of Brahmins
- 3. Ghatikas : Colleges generally attached to the temples

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3
- (d) 1 and 3**

2015

1. Which of the following kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha?

- 1. Avanti
- 2. Gandhara
- 3. Kosala
- 4. Magadha

Select the correct answer using the codes given below.

- (a) 1, 2 and 3 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 3 and 4
- (d) 3 and 4 only**

2. Kalamkari painting refers to

(a) a hand-painted cotton textile in South India

- (b) a handmade drawing on bamboo handicrafts in North-East India
- (c) a block-painted woollen cloth in Western Himalayan region of India
- (d) a hand-painted decorative silk cloth in North-Western India

3. Which of the following kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha?

- 1. Avanti
- 2. Gandhara
- 3. Kosala
- 4. Magadha

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 3 and 4

(d) 3 and 4 only

4. Who of the following founded a new city on the south bank of a tributary to river Krishna and undertook to rule his new kingdom as the agent of a deity to whom all the land south of the river Krishna was supposed to belong?

- (a) Amoghavarsha I
- (b) Ballala II
- (c) Harihara I
- (d) Prataparudra II

5. With reference to the art and archaeological history of India, which one among the following was made earliest?

- (a) Lingaraja Temple at Bhubaneswar
- (b) Rock-cut Elephant at Dhauli**
- (c) Rock-cut Monuments at Mahabalipuram
- (d) Varaha Image at Udayagiri

6. Which one of the following was given classical language status recently?

- (a) Odia**
- (b) Konkani
- (c) Bhojpuri
- (d) Assamese

2014 – TRY ANSWERING THESE

1. Which of the following Kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha?

- 1. Avanti
- 2. Gandhara
- 3. Kosala
- 4. Magadha

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2 and 4
- (c) 3 and 4 only
- (d) 1, 3 and 4

2. Which one of the following pairs does not form part of the six systems of Indian Philosophy?

- (a) Mimamsa and Vedanta
- (b) Nyaya and Vaisheshika
- (c) Lokayata and Kapalika
- (d) Sankhya and Yoga

3. Consider the following towns of India:

- 1. Bhadrachalam
- 2. Chanderi
- 3. Kancheepuram
- 4. Karnal

Which of the above are famous for the production of traditional sarees/fabric?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) 1, 3 and 4

4. Consider the following languages

- 1. Gujarati
- 2. Kannada

3. Telugu

Which of the above has/have been declared as 'Classical Language / Languages' by the Government?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

5. With reference to the famous Sattriya dance, consider the following statements:

- 1. Sattriya is a combination of music, dance and drama.
- 2. It is a centuries-old living tradition of Vaishnavites of Assam.
- 3. It is based on classical Ragas and Talas of devotional songs composed by Tulsidas, Kabir and Mirabai.

Which of the statements above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

6. With reference to the Indian history of art and culture, consider the following pairs:

	Famous work of sculpture	Site
1	A grand image of Buddha's Mahaparinirvana with numerous celestial musicians above and the sorrowful figures of his followers below	Ajanta
2	A huge image of Varaha Avatar (boarincarnation) of Vishnu, as he rescues Goddess Earth from the deep and chaotic waters, sculpted on rock	Mount Abu
3	"Arjuna's Penance" / "Descent of Ganga" sculpted on the surface of huge boulders	Mamalla-puram

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

7. With reference to India's culture and tradition, what is 'Kalaripayattu'?

- (a) It is an ancient Bhakti cult of Shaivism still prevalent in some parts of South India
- (b) It is an ancient style bronze and brasswork still found in southern part of Coromandel area
- (c) It is an ancient form of dance-drama and a living tradition in the northern part of Malabar
- (d) It is an ancient martial art and a living tradition in some parts of South India

8. Consider the following pairs:

- 1. Garba : Gujarat
- 2. Mohiniattam : Odisha
- 3. Yakshagana : Karnataka

Which of the pairs given above is / are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

9. With reference to Buddhist history, tradition and culture in India, consider the following pairs:

	Famous shrine	Location
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1	Tabo monastery and temple complex	Spiti Valley
2	Lhotsava Lhakhang temple, Nako	Zaskar Valley
3	Alchi temple complex	Ladakh

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly atched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

10. A community of people called Manganiyars is well-known for their

- (a) martial arts in North-East India
- (b) musical tradition in North-West India
- (c) classical vocal music in South India
- (d) pietra dura tradition in Central India

11. With reference to the cultural history of India, the term 'Panchayatan' refers to

- (a) an assembly of village elders
- (b) a religious sect
- (c) a style of temple construction
- (d) an administrative functionary

2013

1. Which of the following statements is/are applicable to Jain doctrine?

1. The surest way of annihilating Karma is to practice penance
2. Every object, even the smallest particle has a soul
3. Karma is the bane of the soul and must be ended

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

2. The Chinese traveler Yuan Chwang (Hiuen Tsang) who visited India recorded the general conditions and culture of India at that time. In this context, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. The roads and river-routes were completely immune from robbery.
2. As regards punishment for offences, ordeals by fire, water and poison were the instruments for determining the innocence or guilt of a person.
3. The tradesmen had to pay duties at ferries and barrier stations.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below.

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

3. Which of the following characterizes/ characterize the people of Indus Civilization?

1. They possessed great palaces and temples.
2. They worshipped both male and female deities.
3. They employed horse-drawn chariots in warfare.

Select the correct statement/ statements using the codes given below.

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 only

- (c) 1, 2 and 3
(d) None of the statements given above is correct

4. Some Buddhist rock-cut caves are called Chaityas, while the others are called Viharas. What is the difference between the two?

- (a) Vihara is a place of worship, while Chaitya is the dwelling place of the monks
(b) Chaitya is a place of worship, while Vihara is the dwelling place of the monks
(c) Chaitya is the stupa at the far end of the cave, while Vihara is the hall axial to it
(d) There is no material difference between the two

5. Which one of the following describes best the concept of Nirvana in Buddhism?

- (a) The extinction of the flame of desire
(b) The complete annihilation of self
(c) A state of bliss and rest
(d) A mental stage beyond all comprehension

6. Which of the following characterizes/characterize the people of Indus Civilization?

1. They possessed great palaces and temples
2. They worshipped both male and female deities
3. They employed horse-drawn chariots in warfare

Select the correct statement/statements using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 only
(c) 1, 2 and 3
(d) None of the statements given above is correct

7. With reference to the history of Indian rock-cut architecture, consider the following statements:

1. The caves at Badami are the oldest surviving rock-cut caves in India
2. The Barabar rock-cut caves were originally made for Ajivikas by Emperor Chandragupta Maurya
3. At Ellora, caves were made for different faiths.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

8. In the context of cultural history of India, a pose in dance and dramatics called 'Tribhanga' has been a favourite of Indian artists from ancient times till today. Which one of the following statements best describes this pose?

- (a) One leg is bent and the body is slightly but oppositely curved at waist and neck
(b) Facial expressions, hand gestures and make-up are combined to symbolize certain epic or historic characters
(c) Movements of body, face and hands are used to express oneself or to tell a story
(d) A little smile, slightly curved waist and certain hand gestures are emphasized to express the feelings of love or eroticism

9. Consider the following Bhakti Saints:

1. Dadu Dayal
2. Guru Nanak
3. Tyagaraja

Who among the above was/were preaching when the Lodi dynasty fell and Babur took over?

- (a) 1 and 3
(b) 2 only
(c) 2 and 3
(d) 1 and 2

10. Consider the following historical places:

1. Ajanta Caves
2. Lepakshi Temple
3. Sanchi Stupa

Which of the above places is/are also known for mural paintings?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) None

11. With reference to the history of philosophical thought in India, consider the following statements regarding Sankhya school:

1. Sankhya does not accept the theory of rebirth or transmigration of soul.
2. Sankhya holds that it is the self-knowledge that leads to liberation and not any exterior influence or agent.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

2012

1. With reference to the history of ancient India, which of the following was/were common to both Buddhism and Jainism?

1. Avoidance of extremities of penance and enjoyment
2. Indifference to the authority of the Vedas
3. Denial of efficacy of rituals

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

2. Lord Buddha's image is sometimes shown with the hand gesture called 'Bhumisparsha Mudra'. It symbolizes

- (a) Buddha's calling of the Earth to watch over Mara and to prevent Mara from disturbing his meditation
- (b) Buddha's calling of the Earth to witness his purity and chastity despite the temptations of Mara
- (c) Buddha's reminder to his followers that they all arise from the Earth and finally dissolve into the Earth, and thus this life is transitory
- (d) Both the statements (a) and (b) are correct in this context

3. With reference to the guilds (Shreni) of ancient India that played a very important role in the country's economy, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. Every guild was registered with the central authority of the State and the king was the chief administrative authority on them.
2. The wages, rules of work, standards and prices were fixed by the guild.
3. The guild had judicial powers over its own members.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

4. With reference to the scientific progress of ancient India, which of the statements given below are correct?

1. Different kinds of specialized surgical instruments were in common use by 1st century AD.
2. Transplant of internal organs in the human body had begun by the beginning of 3rd century AD.
3. The concept of sine of an angle was known in 5th century AD.

4. The concept of cyclic quadrilaterals was known in 7th century AD.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 and 4 only
- (c) 1, 3 and 4 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

5. The religion of early Vedic Aryans was primarily of

- (a) Bhakti
- (b) image worship and Yajnas
- (c) worship of nature and Yajnas
- (d) worship of nature and Bhakti

6. The Nagara, the Dravida and the Vesara are the

- (a) three main racial groups of the Indian subcontinent
- (b) three main linguistic divisions into which the languages of Indian can be classified
- (c) three main styles of Indian temple architecture
- (d) three main musical Gharanas prevalent in India

7. With reference to Dhrupad, one of the major traditions of India that has been kept alive for centuries, which of the following statements are correct?

- 1. Dhrupad originated and developed in the Rajput kingdoms during the Mughal period.
- 2. Dhrupad is primarily a devotional and spiritual music.
- 3. Dhrupad Alap uses Sanskrit syllables from Mantras.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) None of the above is correct

8. How do you distinguish between Kuchipudi and Bharatanatyam dances?

- 1. Dancers occasionally speaking dialogues is found in Kuchipudi dance but not in Bharatanatyam.
- 2. Dancing on the brass plate by keeping the feet on its edges is a feature of Bharatanatyam but Kuchipudi dance does not have such a form of movements.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

2011

1. The “dharma” and “rita” depict a central idea of ancient Vedic civilization of India. In this context, consider the following statements:

- 1. Dharma was a conception of obligations and of the discharge of one’s duties to oneself and to others.
- 2. Rita was the fundamental moral law governing the functioning of the universe and all it contained.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

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All thanks to Legendary IAS Mentor for their well curated prelims test series. The questions are well conformed to the original prelims standards. I had faced difficulty in cracking the prelims in my earlier attempts. But each test followed by discussion and individual mentorship helped me strengthen the prelims game through logic training and content enrichment.

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